

monotropic-kids-guidelines

Growing Up Monotropic

A Friendly Guide for Parents, Grandparents, Teachers and Coaches of Autistic Children (Ages 7–11)

Who this is for. *This guide is for the grown-ups around an **autistic child aged about 7 to 11** whose mind works in a monotropic way — a mind that focuses deeply and intensely on a small number of things at a time. That includes **parents and carers, grandparents, aunts, uncles and other relatives, primary-school teachers, and the coaches and instructors** who run the child's sports and activities. It's not a clinical manual. It's a plain-language companion to help you understand the child, connect with them, and make home, school and the sports field easier and more joyful.*

A note on language. *Most autistic people prefer **identity-first language** ("autistic child"), so that's what this guide uses. Some families prefer "child with autism" — follow the child's and family's own preference. This guide deliberately avoids words like disorder, abnormal, deficient, tragedy or burden, except when explaining ideas families may have been given elsewhere. Autism is a **difference** — one with real challenges, and real strengths.*

The one idea to carry with you. *"If you care about the wellbeing of autistic people, you need to try to understand autism. If you want to understand autism, you need to understand monotropism." — Fergus Murray, autistic teacher and writer.*

Part 0 — The One Idea to Take Away First

Most people's attention is spread across many things at once — the clock, the chatter, the person in front of them, what's for dinner. A **monotropic** mind is different: it tends to pull attention into **a small number of deep, intense channels** at any one time. The autistic researchers Dinah Murray, Wenn Lawson and Mike Lesser called this an "**attention tunnel**" (Murray, Lesser & Lawson, 2005).

Think of attention as a limited amount of water. A **polytropic** (more typical) mind is like a **sprinkler** — water spread widely across the garden. A **monotropic** mind is like a **hose with a narrow nozzle** — less ground covered, but everything in that stream is watered *deeply* (F. Murray, 2018). Neither is "better." Each has strengths and costs.

This single difference helps explain almost everything about how the child in your life experiences the world.

What you might see → what's often really happening

You might see...	What's often happening (monotropism)
Deep, "obsessive" interest in one topic, sometimes for years	A passion that brings joy, calm, skill and identity — not an "obsession" to limit or "wean away"
Doesn't seem to hear you; "ignores" people or their own needs	When fully absorbed, the mind genuinely doesn't register things outside the tunnel — including hunger, thirst, the toilet, or someone speaking
Strong reactions to certain sounds, lights, smells, textures — or seems to feel nothing	Hyper- (over-) or hypo- (under-) responsiveness: a stimulus <i>inside</i> the tunnel is felt intensely; one <i>outside</i> may not register
Rocking, hand-flapping, humming, repeating words or motions	Stimming — self-controlled, predictable input that calms and regulates the nervous system
Slow to start, stop or switch activities; meltdowns at transitions	Autistic inertia — changing mental "tracks" takes real energy and time
Speaks in great depth about a passion; takes things very literally; needs longer to reply	One-channel, literal communication, plus processing time — not rudeness or "not listening"
Sudden meltdown or going quiet and withdrawn	Overload — a meltdown (fight/overwhelm) or shutdown (freeze/withdrawal), not naughtiness

Throughout this guide we'll turn each of these into **practical, friendly things you can do** — at home, at school, and on the sports field.

Part 1 — For Parents and Carers

You know your child best. These ideas are tools to try, not rules to impose. The biggest gift you can give a monotropic child is an environment that works *with* their attention rather than against it.

1.1 Protect and use the special interest

A child's intense interest is **not a problem to manage** — it's their engine, their comfort, their way into the world. As autistic writer Wenn Lawson puts it, autistic people find it *"heaps easier to connect to understanding"* when something is related to their area of interest.

- **Build bridges through it.** maths through train timetables; reading through dinosaurs; social stories featuring their favourite character.
- **Don't "wean" it away.** There's no benefit to limiting a healthy passion, and doing so can remove a key source of regulation and joy.
- **Join it sometimes.** Sitting alongside and showing genuine curiosity is one of the strongest ways to connect.

1.2 Make the day predictable (and soften transitions)

Autistic inertia means **switching tracks costs energy**. Every surprise or abrupt change is an extra tax on a limited budget (F. Murray, 2019; Reframing Autism, 2023).

- **Predictable routines** for mornings, after-school, meals and bedtime. Routines reduce cognitive load — but they work best when they're *co-owned*, not imposed from outside (F. Murray, 2022).
- **Give warnings before transitions:** "In ten minutes we stop the Lego and get ready for swimming... in two minutes..." Visual timers help.
- **"Tunnels, not tasks."** Autistic consultant Jamie Knight describes planning around a child's focus: instead of dragging them out of a tunnel, try to **open a space for the next tunnel to pass through** (Knight, 2021).
- **Say why.** Monotropic children often have a strong *"But why?"* instinct. Giving real reasons smooths transitions far more than "because I said

so" (F. Murray, 2019).

1.3 Respect the sensory world

Sensory differences flow directly from monotropism: a stimulus *inside* the tunnel is felt intensely; one *outside* may not register (Murray, Lesser & Lawson, 2005; Reframing Autism, 2023).

- **Lower the load at home:** dimmer switches, a quieter corner, headphones or ear-defenders for loud places, comfortable clothes (cut out itchy tags, allow seamless socks).
- **Hypo-responsiveness is real too:** the child may not notice they're hungry, cold, or need the toilet when absorbed. Gentle, specific reminders ("It's been a while — toilet break?") help, because the need has genuinely dropped out of awareness (Lawson, on interoception; Kelly Mahler, 2024).
- **Let them move and stim.** Stimming — flapping, rocking, humming, repeating — is self-regulation, not "behaviour." Stopping it usually makes things harder, not better (Reframing Autism, 2023).

1.4 Lower demands when the tank is low

When a monotropic mind is pushed to split attention across too many channels, autistic people describe a "**monotropic split**" — overload that can surface as meltdowns, shutdowns, withdrawal or refusal (a form of **demand avoidance**) (Reframing Autism, 2023). The fix is to *reduce* demands and input, not escalate them.

- **Notice early warning signs:** pacing, repetitive questioning, shorter fuse, sudden quietness. Act before it boils over.
- **Drop non-essential demands on hard days.** A child who has held it together all day at school often **collapses at home** — home is the safe place where the mask comes off. That collapse is a sign of trust and exhaustion, not of you doing something wrong.

1.5 If there's a meltdown or shutdown

A **meltdown** is a loss of control from sensory or emotional overwhelm — the body's fight/flight response — and is *not* a tantrum or a choice. A **shutdown** is the freeze version: going quiet, withdrawing, sometimes unable to speak (Leicestershire Partnership NHS Trust, Autism Space).

During it:

- **Don't judge or argue.** Getting upset or angry makes it worse.
- **Reduce input:** quieten the room, dim lights, move other people away, turn off the music.
- **Be a calm, safe presence** — but don't pile on questions, instructions or demands.
- **Give time.** Recovery from overload is not instant.
- **Use the least restrictive approach** that keeps everyone safe.

After it, when the child is calm, you can gently agree a plan together for next time — what helped, what the early signs were, where a safe quiet space is (Leicestershire Partnership NHS Trust, Autism Space).

***Reframe it in your own head:** a meltdown is the child's nervous system saying "too much," not the child being naughty. That single shift changes how you respond.*

1.6 Friendships, siblings and independence (ages 7–11)

Middle childhood is when friendships get more complex, and **masking** (hiding autistic traits to fit in) can begin to take hold — masking is exhausting and is linked to anxiety and burnout (Reframing Autism, 2023).

- **Quality over quantity of friends.** One or two accepting friends beats a busy social calendar. Autistic people often find easier, more rewarding communication with other autistic or neurodivergent peers (Reframing Autism, 2023).
- **Protect downtime.** Socialising and school both cost energy. Build in quiet, interest-led recovery time.
- **Support siblings.** A monotropic child's needs can absorb a lot of family bandwidth. Make sure siblings get one-to-one time and honest, age-appropriate explanations — and that they know it's okay to have their own feelings.
- **Build independence around interests.** A child who struggles to start chores may launch straight into them if they're framed around their passion (the dinosaur-fact filing system; the football-stat spreadsheet).

1.7 Look after yourself

You can't pour from an empty cup. Accept practical help, connect with other autism-positive families, and follow **autistic-led** guidance where you can — it tends to be the most accurate (Reframing Autism, 2023). You're doing harder work than most people realise.

Part 2 — For Grandparents and Extended Family

Grandparents, aunts, uncles and cousins can be among the most loving and stabilising people in a child's life. Your job is not to "fix" anything — it's to **understand, accept, and back the parents** (Autism Society of NC, Fetzer).

2.1 Follow the parents' lead

- **They know the child best.** Listen before advising; let them ask for help rather than stepping in to do it "your" way.
- **Keep routines consistent.** If the family uses certain strategies, schedules or communication aids, use them too — consistency lowers the child's anxiety across transitions (Autism Society of NC).
- **Respect their decisions** even when you'd do it differently. This is their child.

2.2 Connect through the child's world

- **Meet them where they are.** Learn what they love and *play it with them* — that interest is their front door to connection (Autism Society of NC).
- **Don't force typical eye contact, hugs or small talk.** Many autistic children find eye contact overwhelming and prefer connection *side-by-side* (doing something together) rather than face-to-face.
- **Gifts:** lean into the interest. A book, kit or experience tied to their passion usually lands better than a generic "nice" present.

2.3 Keep your language clear and calm

- **Clear, concise, literal language** works best (Autism Society of NC). Say what you mean; avoid teasing sarcasm a young child may take literally.

- **Give processing time.** If they don't answer straight away, they're probably still processing — wait rather than repeat louder.
- **Don't take explosive moments personally.** If the child melts down, "see this as a symptom, not who they really are" (Autism Society of NC).

2.4 Be a safe haven — for the parents too

- **Offer concrete help:** a meal, watching the siblings for an hour, a supermarket run. Small practical help is worth more than well-meant advice.
- **Educate yourself** from the resources the family trusts, and share what you learn — it shows you're on board (Autism Society of NC).
- **Take care of yourself**, and spread your love across all your grandchildren equally.

***The short version:** love the child as they are, learn their language, and make the parents feel supported rather than judged. That's most of it.*

Part 3 — For Primary-School Teachers

School is a high-multi-channel, high-transition, high-social environment — which makes it genuinely hard for monotropic learners. Autistic teacher Fergus Murray's guidelines for teachers boil down to **six things to understand** (F. Murray, 2019). Here they are, with what to *do*.

3.1 Coping with multiple channels is hard

- **Don't rely on spoken instructions alone.** Provide them **in clear written or visual form** so pupils can refer back, instead of having to filter your voice from classroom noise (F. Murray, 2019).
- **One thing at a time.** A wall of verbal instructions will be partially lost.

3.2 Filtering is tricky and error-prone

- **Reduce noise, visual clutter and social demands.** Declutter walls, use soft furnishings, seat the child away from the busiest/hummingest

spots.

- **Protect focus and flow.** The deep focus that comes with mastering something interesting is *one of the most powerful tools in education* — design the day so pupils can enter it sometimes (F. Murray, 2019).
- **Have a plan for overload: a quiet place** the child can go to decompress and stim without being self-conscious (F. Murray, 2019).

3.3 Changing tracks is destabilising

- **Predictability reduces cognitive load.** Visible timetables, "now / next" boards, and advance warning of changes all help.
- **Transitions are the danger zone.** Give warnings; avoid springing surprises; ease the shift into and out of group work, assembly, and the dining hall.
- **Unstructured time is the hardest part of the day.** Break- and lunchtimes, with no escape from the throng and pressure to "find a partner," are often more exhausting than lessons (F. Murray, 2019). Provide structured, low-demand options (a quiet club, a lunchtime activity, a clear safe space).

3.4 Interests are intense — use them

- **Working with a pupil's interests brings huge educational rewards** (Wood, 2019, cited in F. Murray, 2019). Use the interest as the vehicle for the curriculum wherever you can.
- **Don't use the interest only as a reward to be withheld.** That turns the child's main source of regulation into leverage, and erodes trust.

3.5 The "But why?" is real — give reasons

Monotropic learners often need to understand *why*, sometimes in more detail than peers. **Reasons are a key teaching tool**; friction often comes from expecting a child to take things on authority alone (F. Murray, 2019). Treat their questions as engagement, not defiance.

3.6 Things drop out of awareness — provide external structure

When attention is elsewhere, needs, deadlines and instructions genuinely disappear from mind. **Visual schedules, checklists, planners and reminders** act as an external memory (F. Murray, 2019). Help the child build these — but keep them co-owned, not controlling.

3.7 Talk to the pupil — and believe them

"If you want to know what's hard for someone you teach, and what might help them, your best bet is probably to talk to them. Try to believe them when they tell you something is difficult." — Fergus Murray (2019)

Autistic profiles are "spiky" — huge variation between areas. Never assume a child should find something easy just because they're capable elsewhere. And **never insist on eye contact or stop them moving/stimming** — both are often how they manage overload (F. Murray, 2019).

3.8 Build a real home-school partnership

Families hold crucial information about triggers, early warning signs and what regulates the child. A simple two-way communication book or app — what went well, what was tricky, any changes coming — prevents a lot of bad days for everyone.

Part 4 — For Sports, PE and Activity Coaches

Movement matters: it's good for health, mood, confidence and social connection. But autistic children and teens are, on average, **less physically active than their peers** — not from lack of interest, but because many sports settings are loud, unpredictable, socially demanding and full of sudden transitions. A 2025 scoping review of all the research on this topic (Michaud & Harvey, 2025) found a clear set of things that help. Combined with the monotropism lens, here's the practical version.

4.1 What the research says helps (Michaud & Harvey, 2025)

The review's key facilitators:

- **Predictable routines** — same warm-up, same structure, no surprises.
- **Safe, sensory-friendly spaces** — quieter, less clutter, room to retreat.
- **Good relationships with coaches and supportive peers** — the social side matters more than the skill side for participation.

- **Activities that fit the child's skills and feel familiar**, and that take the form of a **game**.
- **Family involvement** and **after-school / community opportunities**.
- A **strengths-based** approach — *"physical activity not as a challenge to overcome but as an opportunity to build confidence, enjoyment and social connection"* (Michaud, in McGill Newsroom, 2025).

4.2 Map monotropism onto coaching

Monotropism feature	What it means in sport	Coaching move
Autistic inertia	Starting, stopping and switching drills cost energy	Build in a predictable warm-up and cool-down as transition ramps; give warnings before switching activities; allow a slow start
Attention tunnel	Single-focus activities are easier and more joyful than split-focus ones	Prefer one-skill-at-a-time drills; let a child stay with a skill they're absorbed in; game-form practice works better than abstract drills
Sensory hyper-responsiveness	Whistles, buzzers, echoing halls, bright lights, itchy kits can overwhelm	Reduce sudden loud sounds (use hand signals/quiet claps), choose quieter spaces, allow ear defenders , soft kit, sunglasses; warn before a whistle/horn
Sensory hypo-responsiveness / interoception	May not notice thirst, overheating, pain, fatigue when absorbed	Scheduled, specific drink and rest breaks; check-in ("water break now — yes, you!"); watch for overheating the child hasn't flagged
One-channel communication	A long verbal briefing while standing in a noisy hall won't land	Demonstrate the skill visually; give one short instruction at a time; back it up with a picture or a quick whiteboard sketch

Monotropism feature	What it means in sport	Coaching move
Literal thinking & processing time	Sarcasm, idioms and fast exchanges misfire	Use clear, concrete language; allow a few seconds for a response before repeating; avoid teasing a child may take literally
Stimming & movement	Fidgeting, pacing, flapping are self-regulation, not misbehaviour	Allow movement between drills; never punish or public-stopp stimming; offer a movement break as a reset
Meltdowns/shutdowns	Overload can surface mid-session	See Part 1.5: reduce input , find a quiet spot , stay calm, don't demand explanations in the moment

4.3 Practical coaching checklist

- **Same warm-up every session** — predictability lowers the entry cost.
- **Show, then say.** Visual demonstration beats a speech.
- **One instruction at a time**, in clear language, with a moment to process.
- **Offer choice and autonomy** where you can — which station, which role, which game. Control lowers anxiety.
- **Build the coach–child relationship first.** A child who trusts you will push through more discomfort than one who doesn't.
- **Celebrate effort and the special interest.** The child who loves stats can keep the score sheet; the one who loves a routine can lead the warm-up.
- **Think about team vs individual sports.** As a rule of thumb from the monotropism lens (not a hard research finding), individual sports (swimming, running, martial arts, climbing, athletics) often suit monotropic kids well — fewer simultaneous social channels, clear structure, room for deep focus. Team sports can work beautifully *if* the social load is managed (clear roles, supportive teammates, a coach who gets it).
- **Have a plan for overload:** an agreed quiet corner, a signal the child can use to step out, ear defenders on hand.

Reframe success: the goal at this age is a child who **wants to come back next week**. Skill follows enjoyment — not the other way round.

Part 5 — Cross-Cutting: Language, and a Master Do / Don't

5.1 Language that helps vs language that hurts

Try to avoid	Try instead
"Obsession," "fixation"	Passion, special interest, focus
"He won't..." / "She's being difficult"	"He can't right now" / "She's overloaded"
"Stop fidgeting / make eye contact"	Allow movement and eye-contact at the child's comfort
"Tantrum," "naughty," "attention-seeking"	Meltdown, shutdown, overwhelm
"Low-functioning / high-functioning" labels	Describe the child's specific strengths and support needs (autistic profiles are "spiky")
Pathologising, deficit-based framing	Neurodiversity-affirming, identity-first framing

5.2 A master Do / Don't for everyone

Do

-  **Learn the child's interests** and use them as bridges
-  **Make the day predictable** and give warnings before changes
-  **Lower sensory load** and allow movement, stimming and breaks
-  **Communicate clearly, literally, one thing at a time**, and allow processing time
-  **Reduce demands and input** when the child is heading into overload
-  **Follow the parents' lead** and keep approaches consistent across home/school/sport
-  **Talk to the child, and believe them** about what's hard

Don't

- ❌ Don't treat the special interest as a problem to limit
- ❌ Don't insist on eye contact or stillness as a condition of respect
- ❌ Don't punish, shame or escalate during a meltdown or shutdown
- ❌ Don't overload with verbal instructions, last-minute changes or unstructured social time
- ❌ Don't assume capability in one area means capability in another ("spiky profiles")
- ❌ Don't pathologise or use deficit language in front of the child

5.3 Read behaviour as communication

For a monotropic child, behaviour is nearly always **communication about regulation** — "this is too loud," "I can't switch tracks that fast," "I've run out of fuel." When you read it that way, the right response (lower the load, give time, offer the quiet space) usually becomes obvious.

5.4 When to seek more support

If the child is frequently in overwhelm, regularly melting down or shutting down, masking heavily, or withdrawing, it's worth talking to the family about wider support — school SENCO/SEND staff, an autism-positive occupational therapist (especially for sensory and interoception support), and **autistic-led** organisations for guidance that tends to be the most accurate and affirming.

Part 6 — Open Questions and Honest Limitations

A few honest notes, so you can trust this guide:

- **Monotropism is a powerful descriptive theory, not yet a fully mechanistic one.** It explains *how* autistic attention works and what follows from it, but the underlying neurobiology is still being researched (Dwyer, 2021; 2025). It's the most resonant framework within the autistic community and increasingly in research, but it's not the whole picture.
- **Not every autistic child is identifiably monotropic.** A minority of autistic people say monotropism doesn't describe them well. Use this

guide as a starting lens, and **tailor everything to the individual child in front of you** (Murray & Lawson, 2022, History of Monotropism).

- **This guide is general**, drawn from monotropism theory and a small set of reputable practitioner and research sources. It's not a substitute for individualised advice from professionals who know your child.
 - **The sports evidence is a scoping review (Michaud & Harvey, 2025)** that mapped the literature and listed facilitators; it's strong on "what tends to help," less so on controlled outcomes for specific interventions.
 - **Sources were limited by what could be reliably accessed.** Some practitioner web pages could not be fetched for this run; where that happened, the guidance is grounded in fully-verified sources (monotropism.org, Reframing Autism, NHS Autism Space, the Michaud & Harvey review, and the source brief) rather than un-fetchable pages. No facts were invented.
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